

ON THE FRONTIERS OF SCIENCE

Scientists predict that we only observe and understand 4 percent of the universe in which we live. Similarly, we are only on the frontiers of exploration when it comes to the science of the human brain, mind, and consciousness, which gets to the heart of yoga's capacity for transformation.

“”

Bear in mind that extraordinary claims require extraordinary evidence.

Q HOW DO I KNOW IF A YOGA STUDY IS RELIABLE?

Not all yoga research is created equally, so it is good to approach it critically. Some factors to consider are:

- **What kind of study is it?** The hierarchy of scientific evidence (see below) gives a good idea of how reliable different kinds of studies are. Evidence that is lower on the pyramid is still valuable, but the higher up, the more reliable. There are increasing systematic reviews and meta-analyses on key topics in

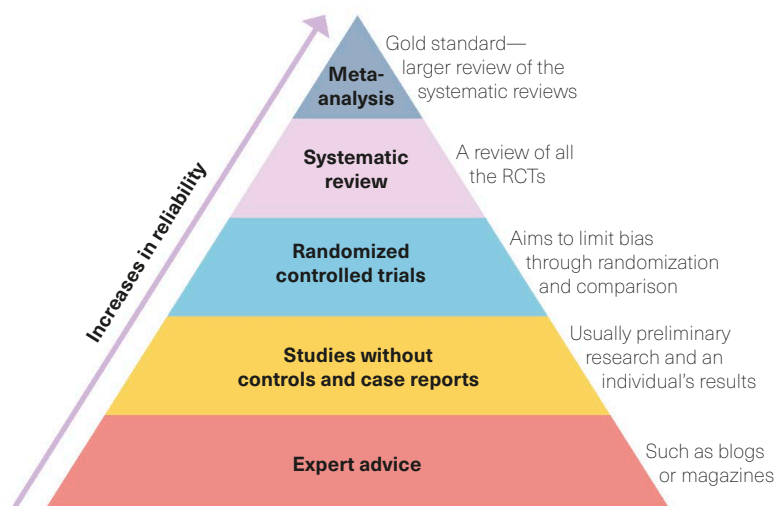
yoga, including mental health, heart disease, chronic pain, and safety.

- **How large is the sample size?**

From case reports of one to randomized controlled trials (RCTs) of 228 people, yoga studies tend to be relatively small, especially compared to pharmaceutical RCTs with up to tens of thousands of participants.

- **Is there a control group? If so, what?** Many yoga studies incorporate a “usual care” control group. A few higher-quality ones have an active control, such as comparing yoga to exercise or talk therapy.

- **What is the conclusion?** Bear in mind that extraordinary claims require extraordinary evidence. This is why many yoga researchers use phrases such as “yoga may improve” or “this suggests that yoga helps.” As interest in yoga research increases, scientists will keep questioning results.



HIERARCHY OF EVIDENCE

You can use this pyramid to gauge the reliability of different types of scientific evidence.